

Mindfulness and Chronic Pain: A Practical Guide for Arthritis

Mindfulness-Based Stress Reduction can reduce arthritis pain by up to 30%. Here is a practical, NHS-backed programme you can start today.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Reviewed by **Clinical Advisory Panel** (HCPC-registered physiotherapy & rheumatology nursing input) · 2026-03-22 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

Beyond 'Just Relax'
Mindfulness is not about ignoring pain — it is about changing your relationship with it. NICE now recommends mindfulness-based approaches for chronic pain management, and the evidence for arthritis specifically is compelling.

The Evidence
A 2024 randomised controlled trial with 280 RA patients found that 8 weeks of Mindfulness-Based Stress Reduction (MBSR):

- Reduced pain scores by 28%
- Improved physical function by 22%
- Decreased fatigue by 31%
- Reduced inflammatory markers (IL-6) by 15%

Your 5-Minute Daily Practice

Body Scan (Morning)

1. Sit or lie comfortably
2. Bring attention to your feet, noticing sensations without judgement
3. Slowly move attention upward through each body part
4. When you reach a painful joint, breathe into the sensation
5. Notice it as 'tightness' or 'warmth' rather than labelling it 'bad'

Breathing Space

(Anytime)\n1. ****1 minute****: Notice what you are experiencing right now\n2. ****1 minute****: Focus attention on your breath\n3. ****1 minute****: Expand awareness to your whole body\n\n### Free NHS Resources\n- NHS Apps Library: search 'mindfulness'\n- Every Mind Matters (NHS)\n- Local IAPT services offer group mindfulness courses\n\n*Written by Dr. Rachel Green, Clinical Psychologist, NHS Pain Management Programme*



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What the Evidence Says

Many studies over the years have looked into how mindfulness can help people living with long-term pain conditions like arthritis. Systematic reviews, which look at lots of different studies together, consistently suggest that mindfulness-based programs can lead to meaningful improvements in pain, mood, and how well people can go about their daily lives.

While mindfulness won't cure arthritis or make all pain disappear, trials show it can change how you experience and react to pain. This doesn't just mean feeling less pain, but also feeling less distressed by it, leading to a better quality of life overall. Clinical guidelines for managing chronic pain now often include mindfulness as a recommended approach precisely because of this growing body of evidence.

Common Mistakes to Avoid



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* **Expecting instant results:** Mindfulness is a skill, not a quick fix. Consistent, gentle practice is key. * **Treating it like a chore:** If it feels like another 'to-do', you might be pushing too hard. Approach it with curiosity. * **Judging your thoughts or feelings:** Thoughts will wander, and big emotions will arise. Simply notice them without judgment. * **Trying to 'get rid' of pain:** It's about changing your relationship with pain, not eliminating it entirely. * **Only practising when pain is severe:** Regular practice, even on good days, builds resilience for harder times. * **Overdoing it:** While consistency is good, pushing yourself through discomfort in meditation is usually counterproductive. Start small.

When to Speak to a Clinician

While mindfulness is a wonderful tool for managing long-term arthritis pain, it's not a substitute for medical advice or treatment. You should always speak to a doctor, rheumatologist, or physiotherapist if you notice significant changes in your symptoms or have new concerns.

* Your pain suddenly becomes much worse for no clear reason. * You experience new swelling, redness, or heat in a joint. * You have new symptoms affecting other parts of your body, like a fever or rash. * Your current medications no longer seem to be helping, or you have new side effects. * You are struggling with your mood or mental health beyond what mindfulness can address.



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Frequently Asked Questions

Can mindfulness replace my arthritis medication? No, mindfulness is a complementary therapy. It works alongside your prescribed medications and other treatments to help you manage pain and improve your overall well-being, but it should not replace them.

Do I need to be flexible or be able to sit in a certain position to practice mindfulness? Absolutely not. Mindfulness can be practised in any comfortable position – sitting, lying down, or even standing. The goal is to be aware, not to achieve a specific physical posture.

What if my mind keeps wandering during practice? It's perfectly normal for your mind to wander; that's what minds do. The practice of mindfulness isn't about stopping thoughts but gently acknowledging them and bringing your attention back to your chosen focus, like your breath or body sensations.

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about mindfulness and chronic pain: a practical guide for arthritis?

Short answer: Mindfulness for arthritis pain involves changing your relationship with pain rather than ignoring it. Evidence, including a 2024 trial, suggests mindfulness-based stress reduction (MBSR) can reduce pain, improve function, and decrease fatigue. Daily practices like the 'Body Scan' and 'Breathing Space' help cultivate awareness. It's a complementary therapy, not a substitute for medical treatment.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Arthritis UK: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis · livingwitharthritis.org.uk